



Springboard to success: After winning the U-17 World Cup with England in 2017, Marc Guéhi (No. 5) made his senior debut for Chelsea two years later. **Left:** Spain's run to the final was powered by a dazzling attacking quartet of Abel Ruiz, César Gelabert, Sergio Gomez and Ferran Torres (standing, in pic). K.R. DEEPAK

to the top has been far from identical.

Kubo's name was known across world football before he was old enough to drive. Dubbed the 'Japanese Messi', he joined Barcelona's famed La Masia academy at the age of 10 before FIFA regulations on the recruitment of foreign minors forced him to return home. Yet the label has followed him everywhere.

"I don't like being compared to Messi, but one day I hope to be like him," Kubo, who now plays for Real Sociedad, had said after he became the second-youngest debutant in J-League history in May 2017.

He has also spoken openly about the difficulties of living abroad at such a young age after scouts from the Catalan giant were impressed by his skills during a Barcelona Soccer Camp in Yokohama in 2009.

"When I was little and went to Barcelona, I didn't think much about

it. I just always wanted to go to Barcelona at any cost," he told Japan's *Soccer Digest* magazine.

"I tried my best not to be bullied as much as possible with my small body. However, sometimes I was beaten by the bigger kids with their fists. It was a very harsh environment."

Nakamura's rise was less glamorous, but perhaps more representative of modern Japanese football. A product of Mitsubishi Yowa's academy, he moved from Gamba Osaka to Dutch side FC Twente on loan in 2019-20. After spells in the Netherlands, Belgium and Austria, he now represents Reims in France.

Japan's remarkable performances in recent years, having lost just one of its last 15 matches, can be attributed to the continuity and seamless progression it has achieved from youth to senior football.

The 2017 FIFA U-17 World Cup